



Run machine: After an injury-hit year, Sarfaraz Khan returns to domestic cricket with a familiar goal — piling on runs for Mumbai. R. RAGU

slot. Karun Nair struggled to hold his place during the England series and was dropped for the home Tests against the West Indies, while B. Sai Sudharsan is yet to look convincing despite consistent backing from the management.

This season could therefore be pivotal for the likes of Devdutt Padikkal and Yash Rathod to build momentum and press their case. Another possibility is elevating Dhruv Jurel to No. 3 once Rishabh Pant returns. The Ranji season is equally crucial for Sarfaraz Khan, who missed much of last year through injury. Fit again, the prolific Mumbai batter will be keen to do what he does best — score heavily and relentlessly.

Of quick turnarounds

Like last year, the Ranji Trophy will be played in phases, a structure many players and coaches prefer as it allows time to recover and recalibrate.

As Indian fast bowler and Saurashtra skipper, Jaydev Unadkat, had said, “Mentally, this arrangement is better for a player as he knows this

is how it is and can plan his workload accordingly.”

Kerala coach Amay Khurasiya has also endorsed the phased format, especially for pacers. “They are all professional players and know their body well. So they know how to get ready,” he said.

For multi-format players, though, the tight scheduling between the Ranji, Syed Mushtaq Ali and Vijay Hazare Trophies remains a challenge.

Movers and shifters

Transfers are nothing new in the Ranji circuit, but this year’s window saw some big moves. Tripura made a splash by signing Hanuma Vihari, Vijay Shankar and Swapnil Singh, while Maharashtra roped in Prithvi Shaw from Mumbai and Jalaj Saxena from Kerala to bolster its lineup. For Shaw, it’s a chance to reset after lean years; for Jalaj, it is a return to familiar surroundings.

Baroda surprised many by signing India wicketkeeper Jitesh Sharma from Vidarbha, which also saw Karun return to his home side Karnataka. On the other hand, veterans like Mandeep Singh, who represented Tripura last season, and Parvez Rasool from Jammu and Kashmir will not feature this year.

Even with experienced names

such as Mohammed Shami, Ajinkya Rahane and Unadkat in action, the selectors’ gaze is likely to remain fixed on emerging talent.

The foreign flavour

After years of domestic coaches dominating the system, two teams have added international expertise. Andhra has brought in New Zealand’s former head coach Gary Stead, while Maharashtra reunited with Australian Shaun Williams, who guided the team to the Syed Mushtaq Ali Trophy in 2010.

Stead, who spent nearly eight years with New Zealand and has coached in Indian conditions before, will bring a fresh perspective. If either Stead or Williams finds success, it could nudge more State units toward experimenting with overseas coaches again.

Pitching it right

One of the BCCI’s crucial instructions to State units this year has been to prepare livelier pitches. The hope is to move away from the spin-heavy surfaces that have dominated recent Ranji seasons. If curators succeed, this could be the most intriguing domestic campaign in years — testing not just India’s next generation of pacers, but also the batters learning to survive and score on more demanding tracks.